constraints. She sketched the executive dominance in policymaking while the military took care of security affairs, including the borderland conflict. However, she argued that lawmakers used legislative tools at their disposal to fulfil their mandate and she attributed this better than expected accomplishment to the role of the speakers, political space for minority parties within tolerable boundaries inside the legislature, and the effective engagement by community-based organizations for giving input. Renaud Egreteau (2014, p. 60) accepted the positive role played by the Hluttaw with a cautious warning that lack of capacity, institutional constraints, and signs of emerging clientelist and patrimonial politics may undermine the "euphoric optimism" of the legislature in the long run.

THE HLUTTAW'S RESPONSE TO CONFLICTS

Resource-based disputes

During the transition one of the most contentious resource-based disputes affecting all the country was conflict that arose from land grabbing by the military, government agencies, and business companies. According to the government, from September 2013 to September 2014, there were 7,615 cases of land-grabbing disputes at its peak, covering over 122,300 hectares of land: comparable to the size of Hong Kong (President's Office 2014a). During the military regime, land grabbing was mostly carried out by the military to extend its bases and the government for various development projects. But because of increased business opportunities, coupled with a surge in foreign direct investment, the private sector led by business cronies became increasingly involved in land grabbing through formal and informal means (Woods 2014). At the same time, thanks to significant freedom of expression garnered during the transition, people started to express their grievances on their land being grabbed with less fear.

The land-grabbing issue was initially introduced into the legislature on 26 September 2011 by the Public Complaints and Petition Committee of the Amyotha Hluttaw after receiving an alarming number of complaints of land grabbing by private entities. The committee chair U Aung Nyein from the ruling USDP said in his speech, "Mishandling of local authorities, not abiding by the laws and lacking co-ordination has resulted in the loss